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STANDING UP FOR MYSELF

In July 2001, two months after the Australia series, we played a tri-series against the West Indies and Zimbabwe at Harare. I had trained hard in the off season and felt in good shape ahead of the series. For close to two years, between August 1999 and July 2001, I had been injury-free and the off-season training had definitely helped improve my fitness. I used to run in the mornings and do gym sessions in the afternoon to strengthen my upper body and I also kept a check on my diet. The discipline had helped and the 1999 back injury was now just a bad memory.

I started the tournament in red-hot form and scored two fifties and a century in the four pool games, being dismissed only once. But just as I had started to look forward to the final, I suffered the second major injury of my career in rather unexpected circumstances.

It happened during the last of our group matches against the West Indies on 4 July 2001. Rahul and I were batting together and we were cruising to victory. With some 20 runs left to win, I turned a ball to midwicket and set off for two runs. That's when I heard something click in my big toe. Immediately I felt a sense of discomfort and found it difficult to complete the second run. Before the next ball I walked up to Rahul and said that I had hurt my toe and that the temperature in my foot had suddenly gone up a few degrees. However, with so few runs needed, I decided to stay in and finish off the game as quickly as possible, making 122 in the process.

After the match I showed the toe to Andrew Leipus, who had taken over as our physiotherapist, and the next morning we went for an X-ray.